In the second Test of the home series at Eden Gardens at the end of November 1996, South Africa beat us comfortably, with Lance Klusener and Gary Kirsten playing well for the visitors. Klusener took eight wickets on debut and Gary scored hundreds in both innings. One of South Africa's most prolific opening batsmen, Gary had the remarkable ability to pick up singles at will with a nudge into the gap between midwicket and square leg. This made him an extremely difficult batsman to bowl to. A fierce competitor, he is someone I had the highest respect for as an opponent.

We went to Kanpur for the third Test with the series level. Azhar was in commanding form in the second innings, remaining undefeated on 163, and once we had managed to set South Africa a target of over 450 we knew we were in control. We bowled South Africa out for 180, winning the Test by 280 runs and the series 2–1. To beat Australia and South Africa in my first two series as captain was the best start I could have hoped for, and when we left for South Africa in December 1996 we were a team brimming with confidence.

India in South Africa, December 1996–February 1997

The planning for the return series was not the best. We landed in South Africa on 19 December and played just one practice game before the first Test match in Durban on Boxing Day. On a tour like that you really need at least two or three practice games and close to two weeks of acclimatization to be competitive. The conditions are so different from those in India that players have to have that time to get used to the seam movement and the bounce. Balls that hit the bottom half of the bat in India come at heights close to the bat handle in South Africa.

We lost the Durban Test miserably, bowled out by the South African fast bowlers for 66 in the second innings in just thirty-four overs. It was a demoralizing loss and I had never experienced anything like it before. South Africa proved superior to us in all aspects of the game and we were left with a huge amount of work to do ahead of the second Test at Cape Town.

To add to my problems, I had injured myself in Durban while bowling and the injury was taking a few days to heal. It happened when I decided to bowl to Andrew Hudson just before lunch on the first day. I thought I